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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: RSS

People with kids, motorcycles and other goods crossing Karnali River on an old ferry at Sankatti between Bardiya and Kailali districts.

PM directs for swift police adjustment

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 17



Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has instructed all concerned state bodies to complete the adjustment of police personnel as soon as possible.

Holding a meeting with Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Home Affairs Narayan Kaji Shrestha, other federal ministers, Chief Secretary Dr. Baikuntha Aryal, Inspector General of Police (IGP) Basanta Bahadur Kunwar and officials of the Ministry of Home Affairs (MoHA) on Wednesday, PM Prachanda asked everyone to be serious about adjusting police personnel as the issue had prevented the provinces from working fully.

He said, "Federalism has not been implemented as fast as it should have been. On the one hand, this has hindered the provincial governments from working while on the other, this has provided ammunition to anti-federalist forces to criticise the system."

He requested everyone present at the meeting to finish the adjustment process within 15 days as per the Nepal Police and Province Police (Operation, Supervision and Coordination) Act, 2020. Meanwhile, in a separate meeting with Home Minister Shrestha, Minister for Labour, Employment and Social Security Sharat Singh Bhandari and secretaries of relevant ministries, noted complaints about Nepalis going abroad with work permits and visit visas being harassed at the airport and asked officials to bring an end to that.

He said, "I have heard complaints of airport staff sending travellers back for lack of papers and then engaging in inappropriate settings. Please ensure that those going abroad, including on visit visas, are being treated as per the immigration regulations. Look into it that they are not bothered unnecessarily."

Cabinet makes several appointments

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 17

A cabinet meeting held on Wednesday has made appointments to the Cultural Corporation, Naradevi Ayurveda Hospital, Shahid Gangalal National Heart Centre and the Citizen Investment Trust.

The meeting of the Council of Ministers appointed Kiran Babu Pun as the General Manager of the Cultural Corporation, Ramesh Chandra Neupane as the Chairman of the Naradevi Hospital's Development Committee, Dr. Ravi Malla as the Executive Director of the Shahid Gangalal Centre and Parbat Kumar Karki as the Executive Director of the Citizen Investment Trust.

Similarly, as per the information provided by the Prime Minister's Office, the cabinet decided to table the bill to amend the Political Parties Act, 2017, in the federal parliament and recommended the President issue an ordinance to amend the Fiscal Procedures and Financial Accountability Act-2019.

RELATION BETWEEN NEPAL, INDIA INTERCONNECTED: VICE PRESIDENT

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 17

Vice President Ramsahay Prasad Yadav said that as close neighbours, the past, present and future of Nepal and India were interconnected.

During a meeting with Indian Ambassador to Nepal, Naveen Srivastava, who called on him at the VP's official residence in Lainchaur on Wednesday, Vice President Yadav said that friendship and collaboration should be further strengthened for progress and prosperity of the people of both countries. "India is an important development partner of Nepal. We have been receiving remarkable support from India in different sectors including financial and technical support", he mentioned.

The Vice President also said that Nepal-India collaboration in aviation, road and railway, petroleum pipeline, hydropower, development of transmission line, establishment of integrated check post and human resources development sector was significant. On the occasion, the Indian Ambassador stated that India had always supported Nepal's development endeavours and would continue its support in coming days, according to the office of the Vice-President.

Saud stresses deeper cooperation to solve global problems

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 17



Minister Narayan Prakash Saud

Minister for Foreign Affairs, Narayan Prakash Saud, Minister for Foreign Affairs of Nepal, has expressed concerns over the rise of protectionism and economic nationalism, of late.

Addressing the NAM (Non-Aligned Movement) Ministerial Meeting in Kampala, Uganda, on Wednesday, Minister Saud said that while protectionism and economic nationalism were on the rise, urgent call for the reform of global economic and financial systems goes unheard.

"In this intensely globalised and deeply interconnected world, deeper cooperation is essential for finding solutions to global or regional problems we are facing. Yet, promises and commitments made to provide Official Development Assistance (ODA) to the developing countries and the Least Developed Countries (LDCs) are not fulfilled," said FM Saud.

The NAM Ministerial Meeting is being organised with the theme of "Deepening Cooperation for Shared Global Affluence". It will run till Thursday, January 18.

The Foreign Minister stated that the NAM must play a pivotal role in promoting multilateralism, defending the UN Charter and international law, finding peaceful solutions to disputes, reforming the global financial architectures, creating a just global economic order for shared affluence.

FM Saud suggested that the NAM must assert its collective voice to create an inclusive global order where all countries can prosper together, sharing global affluence equitably.

According to him, the NAM, as a strong block with 120 countries representing around 60 per cent of the world's population, holds both majority and moral strengths to devise solutions to global problems that we face today- from conflicts to climate change; economic injustice to social inequality; the digital divide to debt distress, and hunger to disease.

"We must advocate for strong collaboration at the global level, while securing collaboration among ourselves for trade, investment, technology transfer, and more," he said and called for support to each other's development aspirations, avoidance of vicious trap of suspicion and rivalry amongst the NAM member countries.

He also said that the NAM should evolve into a dynamic forum to shape a global order to address the interlocking global challenges of our time based on its founding principles.

According to FM Saud, the NAM movement has become a powerful political voice free from the prejudice of the polarity.

"We are facing a multitude of crises and challenges. They include the persistent impact of COVID-19 pandemic, climate change, conflicts, soaring food and energy prices, inflation, debt burdens to name but a few," he said while stating that the world is witnessing the worst nightmare in Gaza and has been bearing the brunt of the Ukraine war.

It is perplexing that as per the Global Peace Index, the deaths from global conflict increased by 96 per cent in 2023, and 91 countries are now involved in some form of conflict, said Minister Saud.

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EC requests govt to arrange security for NA election

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 17

On Wednesday, the Election Commission of Nepal instructed the government to make security arrangements for the National Assembly election slated for January 25. A meeting of the ECN held on Wednesday instructed the Home Ministry to implement its 9-point directions to make the election operation manageable by providing security for voters, candidates, election offices, staffers, election materials, and polling centres to make the election impartial by providing reliable security.

The ECN gave the direction to the government on the recommendation of the High-Level Election Security Committee meeting held on Tuesday. The committee is headed by Election Commissioner Sagun Shumsher JBR.

The EC in its statement directed the government to provide necessary security by mobilising the security bodies under the Home Ministry's coordination as per the work plan of the Commission to transport the ballot papers, provide necessary security to the staffers deployed in the election, security to voters and their hotels in coordination with respective Chief District Offices. It also instructed to make security arrangement in polling stations and polling centres and vote counting area.

The EC also instructed to make the district election security committees active and provide necessary information on the implementation of the election code of conduct.

The ECN also called the voters to bring their voter identity card, citizenship, national identity card and necessary original documents to cast their vote.

'Make academic programmes in universities practical'

RSS
Kirtipur (Kathmandu), Jan. 17

Minister for Information and Communications Technology Rekha Sharma, has called for making University academic programmes more practical and relevant to entrepreneurship and the job market. During the signing of a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) between the Central Department of Computer Science and Information Technology, Tribhuvan University, and the Digital Empowerment Society, the Minister highlighted the vital role of the IT sector in achieving economic prosperity in the current era.

The MoU aims to provide training opportunities for Master's level students at the Department of Computer Science and Information Technology, TU specifically in Microsoft companies.

The agreement was signed by Department Chief Sarbin Sayami and Society Chair Rajendra Aryal, representing their respective sides, in the presence of Minister Sharma.

Minister Sharma stressed the importance of bridging the gap between TU educational programmes and the consumer sector to prove wrong the narrative that university graduates are not immediately qualified for the job market. Everyone entering the job market ahead should be trained with new IT skills. This approach could generate interest in academic streams that currently attract fewer students, she said.

Stating that IT was a subject of international competition and students could earn foreign currency working from home, the Minister viewed that the University should be more active in producing skilled manpower in this sector.

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Waterbirds decline in Narayani River

BY MEENA KANDEL
Kawasoti, Jan. 17

The number of waterbirds visiting East Nawalparasi has decreased due to human activities, coupled with recent developments around the wetlands.

The waterbird census reveals a consistent decline in the number of birds found in the area each year, attributed to the destruction of the wetlands.

Ruddy Shelduck, commonly called Chakhewa in Nepali, used to be abundantly seen along the Narayani River towards Nawalpur. DB Chaudhary, the Bird Count Coordinator of Chitwan National Park West Sector, said that the number of birds has decreased by 50 per cent this year.

In the bird census conducted in 2021, 47 bird species were recorded in the area, whereas in 2022, only 37 species were documented. In last year's



bird count, 43 species were identified, and this year, the number has further decreased to 41 species in the Narayani River area.

According to Chaudhary, the decline in the number of birds is attributed to both natural causes and human activities. Additionally, disruptions in their migratory routes, likely caused by changes in the environment, have contributed to the decrease. He added that two species were found in fewer numbers compared to the previous year.

The Eurasian Wigeon (Sindhure Hans), Common Pochard (Kailetauke Hans), Kentish Plover (Alak Chandra Raj Putrika), Wood Sandpiper (Ban Sud Sudia), and Dunlin (Thulo Jal Rang) were observed for the first time in the Narayani River, which were absent during last year's bird count.

Chaudhary reported that eight bird species observed last year were not present this year, while six new bird species were identified during the current year's bird count.

The decline in bird numbers is attributed to the disappearance of habitats essential for their migration, thanks to global warming. Chaudhary added, "The rivers are becoming increasingly polluted with the daily mixing of sewage and garbage into water sources, causing water bodies to dry up.

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PHOTO: RAJAN RAWAT/TRN

A Simrik Airlines helicopter carrying edible goods for Humla people as Food Management and Trade Company Ltd in the district has the responsibility to distribute foods for the people every year.

Central grid's electricity supply reaches Bheri

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Jajarkot, Jan. 17

The electricity supplied from the central grid has reached in Bheri Municipality and Shivalaya Rural Municipality. As part of the government's Bright Nepal Campaign, the Nepal Electricity Authority has started to supply electricity through the national grid in two municipalities of Jajarkot and has worked in other municipalities.

About 10 years ago, the work to connect the district by the national transmission line with the aim of providing light to the people living with oil lamps and lantern, improving the income of the people by running businesses, and benefiting the government after making them self-dependent.

Abhishesh Raj Kalwar, chief of Nepal Electricity Authority, Jajarkot Distribution Centre, said that all 13 wards of Bheri Municipality, all the wards except Ward No. 4 of Shivalaya Rural Municipality, have the line installed and people have been able to use electricity.

The work of electricity connection is going on in Ward No. 6 of Shivalaya Rural Municipality, he said, adding that after the completion of the work in that Ward, work starting from Ward No. 4, all general people of all wards will get electricity by January end, this year.

In Nalgad Municipality, electricity access has reached to 70 per cent of the population, while work is under way to ensure the access of electricity to the remaining 30 per cent population. In Chhedagad Municipality, 50 per cent of the villages have lights on, while 50 per cent of the villages have not been connected. The electricity of the central grid has not reached other settlements apart from Kushe Rural Municipality-5.

Kalwar said that electricity of the central grid has not been extended in Junichande Rural Municipality and Barekot Rural Municipality. Even though the NEA has aimed to expand central electricity in all the seven municipalities of Jajarkot within two years, people will not be able to get electricity within two years due to the slowness of the contactors.

As the central transmission line could not be extended in Barekot and Junichande Rural Municipality the people of the rural areas are still forced to use oil lamps and solar lights. In Chhedagad Municipality, although electricity has reached in 50 per cent of the villages, the extension of electricity has been delayed due to the delay in installing poles and extending the wires in other villages, said Kalwar.

The office has also asked the contractors to complete the work of erecting poles and extend the wires in time in order to expand electricity in all the seven municipalities of Jajarkot. If the construction businessmen who have taken the contract cannot complete the work on time, the construction businessmen who have taken over the work will be blacklisted.

Bhawani Prasad Sharma of Bheri Municipality 4 said that after the extension of electricity line, the people have their work eased. After the expansion of electricity, the industry has been registered and self-employment and employment has been created, he said.

Gold price drops to Rs. 118,200 per tola

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 17

The prices of gold and silver have decreased noticeably on Wednesday. The price of gold has dropped by Rs. 1,200 per tola in the domestic market Wednesday as compared to Tuesday.

According to the Federation of Nepal Gold and Silver Dealers' Association (FENEGOSIDA), the price of gold decreased to Rs. 118,200 per tola (11.664 grams) today compared to Rs. 119,400 on Tuesday. Likewise, the price of silver has also decreased by Rs. 15 per tola to Rs. 1,400.

Earlier on December 28, price of gold had reached Rs. 122,000 tola in the local market. The price of gold has decreased sharply on Wednesday in the local market due to decrease in its price in the international market, said Tej Ratna Shakya, gold trader and special member of the FENEGOSIDA.



According to him, with the rise in the exchange rate of the US dollar, the price of gold has come down as investors have been attracted to the dollar and the pressure to sell gold has started. "Selling pressure of gold has led to reduction in its price in the international market as the international investors are encouraged to sell gold by ensuring profit," he said.

Fluctuations in the international market price have their impact in the domestic bullion market as well, he said. Gold price in the international market has decreased by US$ 25 per ounce to US$ 2,024 today, he said. Price of gold was USD 2,049 per ounce in the international market on Tuesday.

The present scenario shows that the price of gold would further decline in the international market, he said. "But, we cannot predict the price of gold would increase or decrease in this situation as the price of gold has been fluctuating significantly," he said.

Even though the wedding season has started, the demand for gold has not increased in the local market, he said. The demand for gold stands below 20 kgs daily at present, he said. The decline in the purchasing power of people and high gold price are the main reasons behind the low business of gold even in wedding season, said Shakya.

AANDHIKHOLA MAHOTSAV CONCLUDES

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Syangja, Jan. 17

The second Syangja Aandhikhola Festival concluded with a financial transaction worth Rs. 38 million. According to the organisers, about 57,000 visitors attended the festival, which was conducted in Putlibazaar Municipality-1, Malebagar, on January 4.

Although there were 200 stalls in the festival, of which 153 were allocated for commercial companies.

The organisers said that the upcoming festival will be designed to promote agricultural products and technology, domestic products, science and technology, information technology, rural tourism, archaeological importance, literature and culture.

Shrawan Tole Development Organisation of Putlibazaar-14 won first place in Ratyauli (song sung by women at the bridegroom's house while the latter leaves to bring his bride) competition, Shrijana Mothers Group won second prize and Jugle Mother Group won the third place.

Maisthan Tole Development Organisation was awarded for best bridegroom and best dance, while Jaisidanda Mother Group received the best dance award.

Likewise in Naumati Baja competeition, Ukhari Naumati Baja won first place and Ariyale Naumati Baja group came second.

Yeti Brewery IPO deal



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 17

Yeti Brewery Limited has appointed NIMB Ace Capital Limited as the portfolio manager for issuing Initial Public Offering through the book-building method. The agreement regarding the issue of shares has been signed by Sanjeev Saraf, Managing Director of Yeti Brewery Limited and Sachindra Dhungana, General Manager on behalf of NIMB Ace.

Yeti runs its brewery factory in Khairhani Municipality, Ward no.- 4 in Chitwan district. It produces beer brands such as Arna, Yeti, YB, Shikhar and Kingfisher. Under the said agreement, NIMB Ace will provide the service of portfolio manager in all the works related to the public issue and management of the ordinary shares of Yeti Brewery through the book-building method.

Cardamom traded at highest price



FILE PHOTO: TRN

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Taplejung, Jan. 17

The cardamom was traded at the highest price of this year in the district on Tuesday. A sack of cardamom (40 kg) was traded for Rs. 77,000 in Phungling market, district headquarters of Taplejung. The price of cardamom sold on Tuesday is the highest this season.

Bhadrabir Regmi, President of Taplejung Cardamom Entrepreneurs' Association, said that the price of cardamom reached Rs. 77,000 per 40 kg in the market this year. It is the highest price of cardamom this year. According to him, the price of cardamom had been continuously increasing at the rate of Rs. 1,000 and Rs. 2,000 per 40 kg for the past few days.

He said that cardamom is traded at Rs. 77,000 per 40 kg in the market of Taplejung, but in Birtamod of Jhapa, it is traded at up to Rs. 79,000 per 40 kg. As the price of cardamom continues to increase, local farmers and businessmen are happy.

The current price of cardamom is the highest not only for this year but for the past four to five years. Businessmen said that cardamom was traded ranging from Rs. 26,000 to Rs. 32,000 per 40 kg last year.

According to local businessmen, in the last four to five years, cardamom had been traded for a minimum of Rs. 20,000 and a maximum of Rs. 35,000 per 40 kg. This year, when the new cardamom started to arrive in the market, it was being traded ranging from Rs. 60,000 and Rs. 65,000 per 40 kg.

According to local businessmen, after the main harvesting season of cardamom started, the initial price of cardamom decreased to Rs. 53,000. Traders have said that the price of cardamom has remained the same for a long time.

Trader Kamal Baral said that the price of cardamom, which has been slowly rising for the last few weeks, has reached Rs. 77,000 by Tuesday. Even though the price of cardamom is constantly increasing, farmers have said that they have already sold a lot of cardamom. They said that the production of cardamom has decreased this year as compared to last year.

In Taplejung, cardamom is being cultivated in an area of about 4,500 hectares. According to the statistics of Agriculture Knowledge Centre, Taplejung, up to 2,500 tonnes of cardamom can be produced from this farm.

NEA cuts power-lines of consumers in Tanahun



BY AMAR RAJ NAHARKI
Tanahun, Jan.17

Nepal Electricity Authority, Tanahun Distribution Centre has cut off the lines of customers who had not been paying their bills regularly and recovered Rs. 7.541 million.

According to the Centre, the amount was recovered by cutting the lines of those who did not pay their electricity tariffs from mid-July 2023 to mid-January 2024 of the current fiscal year.

Bijaya Raj Regmi, chief engineer, said that the Centre has recovered the dues from 440 customers out of the 516 customers whose power supply had been disconnected.

He said that the outstanding amount has been recovered by cutting power supply as part of the campaign to disconnect the lines of the customers who have not paid bills within 60 days.

He said that under the campaign, the line of Araniko Cement Factory located in Aanbookhaireni Rural Municipality, which has the highest arrears of Rs. 7.281 million, has been cut.

According to him, about Rs. 4.267 million from 286 customers of Damauli Distribution Centre, Rs. 3.5 million from 153 customers of Dumre Distribution Centre and Rs. 9.879 million from 516 customers of Aanbookhaireni should have been recovered.

Out of about Rs. 17.6 million that should have been collected from 516 consumers, only Rs. 7.541 million has been collected from 440 consumers, he said.

After the amount is recovered, the line of those customers is connected.

As part of the campaign, after the chief of the Centre Regmi himself went to cut the line, the number of electricity users who did not pay their dues began to decrease, said Ramesh Sigdel, account chief of Tanahun Distribution Centre.

According to the Centre, the lines of the customers who have a huge amount of arrears will be disconnected at the beginning, and gradually the lines of all those who do not pay the arrears will be disconnected.

The electricity users who do not pay the electricity dues even after six months will be blacklisted and the recovery process will be initiated, Sigdel said. There is a provision of 2 per cent discount for seven days after meter reading. The amount as per the bill has to be paid by the 15th day.

From the 16th day of the meter reading to the 30th day, there is a provision to charge an additional fee at the rate of 5 per cent and from the 31st day to the 40th day at the rate of 10 per cent. Consumers who do not pay the electricity tariff even on the 40th day from the date of meter reading will be charged an additional fee of 25 per cent of the bill from the 41st day.

There is a provision to cut the line if the arrears are not paid even by the 60th day after the additional charge of 25 per cent. There is a provision to blacklist the consumers who do not pay the arrears even six months after the line is disconnected and the recovery process will be set in motion.

KMC collects Rs. 5 billion revenue

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 17

The Kathmandu Metropolitan City (KMC) collected around Rs 5 billion in revenue in the first half of the current fiscal year 2023/24.

The collection is higher by around 350 million than that of the corresponding period in the last fiscal year.

KMC Revenue Department Chief Dhruba Kafle told Rastriya Samachar Samiti (RSS) that the highest revenue collection for the KMC was from the house rent tax at over Rs 1.35 billion followed by tax in property at over Rs 670 million.

The swelling in the size of tax payers is attributed to increase in revenue collection. The KMC has aimed to generate over Rs 10 billion in revenue for the current fiscal year.

KMC has been collecting revenue under 36 different headings including property, home maintenance, business registration, advertisement, entertainment, real estate, VAT and vehicles among others, informed Kafle.

If revenue collection goes in the same pace, the KMC would meet its annual revenue collection target at the end of the fiscal year, he viewed.

The KMC intensifying the tax collection drive also led to collect the outstanding amount since long thereby contributing to increase in revenue collection.

S. KOREA'S IMPORT PRICE FALLS

AGENCIES
Jan.17

Price for imported goods to South Korea fell for the second straight month in December 2023 on the back of cheaper crude oil and the local currency's ascent versus the U.S. dollar, central bank data showed Tuesday. The import price index dipped 1.7 percent in December from a month earlier after sliding 4.4 percent in the previous month, according to the Bank of Korea (BOK). Dubai crude, South Korea's benchmark, averaged 77.33 U.S. dollars per barrel in December, down 7.4 percent from the prior month.

The average won/dollar exchange rate declined to 1,303.98 won per dollar in December from 1,310.39 won in the previous month.

Schools shut in Tarai to save children from cold

BY OUR CORRESPONDENTS
Biratnagar/Inaruwa/Gaur, Jan. 17

In response to the chilling cold wave across the Tarai, schools have been shut in Morang and Sunsari in Koshi and Rautahat in Madhes Province.

According to our Biratnagar correspondent Shashidhar Parajuli, schools in Biratnagar will remain closed for three days. The Biratnagar Metropolitan Corporation issued a public notice, officially declaring the closure of schools from Wednesday to Friday (January 19). Consequently, regular classes will resume only on Sunday, January 21.

The decision to grant a three-day holiday to educational institutions within the metropolitan area is attributed to concerns about potential health risks for students and challenges in carrying out academic activities amid the extreme cold weather.

The Terai district, including Morang, has experienced a noticeable drop in temperature due to the ongoing cold wave.

As of Tuesday afternoon, the temperature in Biratnagar hovered around 9 degrees Celsius, and on Wednesday, it registered at approximately 12 degrees Celsius. Krishna Bhattarai, the officer of the educational administration division of the metropolitan city, said that any further decisions would be contingent upon a reassessment of the situation after three days.

The metropolitan authorities are closely monitoring the weather conditions, and additional updates or decisions will be communicated as needed, read the notice. It is advised for students, parents, and the community to stay informed about any developments through official channels during this temporary school closure.

Meanwhile in Inaruwa, responding to the cold weather and the effects of fog, several local levels; in Sunsari have decided to temporarily close schools. Itahari Sub-metropolitan City has announced the suspension of school activities until January 19. With the winter conditions intensifying in recent days, the municipalities and sub-metropolitan cities jointly declared a three-day closure of schools, prioritising the health and well-being of students.

Dilliraj Niraual, the head of the education branch, said that Inaruwa Municipality had initially declared the closure until January 16.

However, given the unabated cold weather, a subsequent decision was made to extend the school closure until January 19. Majority of schools in Sunsari, covering areas such as Inaruwa, Itahari, and Gadhi, have temporarily shut down due to the cold wave.

Meanwhile, Dron Prasad Dahal, the education officer of the sub-metropolitan city, informed that schools in the Itahari would also be closed until January 19.

A directive has been issued to all community, religious, and child development centres, instructing them to close schools during this period as part of the annual vacation. The official notice read, "Due to the ongoing extreme cold and cold wave affecting daily teaching activities, an accumulated fifty annual leave days will be deducted till January 19 within this Sub-metropolitan City. Children's development centres are also advised to adhere to this directive.



PHOTO: TRN

As cold increase, schools shut in Tarai to save children from cold, and common people benefiting from the firewood provided by Gaur Municipality to fight the chilling cold.

The severe cold has presented challenges for locals residing in various areas, including Duhawi, Inaruwa, Bhokraha Narsingha, Koshi, Harinagar, Dewanganj, Gadhi, Ramdhuni, Itahari, Dharan, Barahakshetra and others, hindering their ability to venture outside their homes.

Similarly, Rautahat district is also currently grappling with harsh weather conditions characterised by extreme cold and thick fog over the past two weeks, significantly impacting daily life, especially for children and the elderly. Deepak Shrestha of Munali Child Academy in Gaur, reported school was closed in compliance with Gaur Municipality's directive, prompted by the intensifying cold.

Uday Devkota, the head of the Land Revenue Office in Rautahat, noted a significant decline in pedestrian activity on the streets as people opt to stay indoors, venturing out only for essential tasks.

The increasing number of patients seeking treatment due to the cold wave has resulted in a surge in health institutions' occupancy.

The Provincial Hospital Gaur reported an uptick in patients, spanning from children affected by winter ailments to the elderly. Dr. Rajesh Singh, Chief Physician of the emergency department, highlighted a rise in cases of pneumonia, cold-related diarrhoea in children, and respiratory issues such as asthma and cough among the elderly.

Dr. Singh strongly advised individuals to limit outdoor activities, don warm clothing, use blankets, and ensure access to heating sources to mitigate the impact of the cold.

Similarly, Jagannath Keshari, President of the Civil Society, appealed to all 18 municipalities to organise the distribution of firewood in the Bajaria area and urban regions. This initiative aims to provide relief and protect the community from the escalating winter conditions.

NEPAL, INDIA ENJOY UNIQUE TIES, SAYS MINISTER ACHARYA

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Taulihawa, Jan. 17

Minister for Women, Children, and Senior Citizen Surendra Raj Acharya has said that Nepal and India share an immeasurable relationship.

Speaking at a one-day conference on the social and cultural relationship of Nepal and India organised by the Nepal-Bharal Millat Council in Kapilvastu on Wednesday, Minister Acharya said that Nepal and India shared religious, cultural and social ties and everyone should be responsible for preserving them.

He said that citizens of both countries could freely travel between them, and such relationships were rare in other countries worldwide.

Stating that Nepal-India not just share 'Roti-Beti' relationship, he said that both countries shared relationships in areas of marriage, culture, religion, tourism and employment.

Former Foreign Minister Pradeep Kumar Gyawali said that India had achieved significant milestones in the past 75 years.

He said that Nepal was pleased to witness India's progress as a neighbouring country.

NRNA hands over mobile blood bus to Koshi Red Cross

BY NISHA RAI
Kathmandu, Jan. 17

The Non-Resident Nepali Association (NRNA) has handed over a mobile blood bus to the Dharan Red Cross Society of Koshi Province.

The mobile bus was handed over to the Blood Transfusion Service Center run by the Sunsari District Branch by the NRNA on Wednesday.

President of the NRNA, Dr. Badri KC, and Chief Minister of Koshi, Kedar Karki, handed the Rs. 7-million bus over to Umesh Thapa, President of Red Cross Society Sunsari, the NRNA informed in a statement.

Speaking on the occasion, CM Karki asked the non-resident Nepalis to cooperate for the prosperity of Koshi Province. He said that there are many possibilities for investment in the province and proposed to work together with the non-resident Nepalis to cooperate in potential areas of investment there.

He said that there should be unity among the Nepalis living abroad and there should be no differences between the Nepalis living in Europe and America and those living in the Middle East.



PHOTO: NISHA RAI

At a hand over ceremony, the Non-Resident Nepali Association (NRNA) handing over a mobile blood bus to the Dharan Red Cross Society of Koshi Province, Wednesday.

Chief Minister Karki said that many women still die due to lack of blood during childbirth at a young age as they are often forced into early marriages.

Chief Minister Karki thanked the NRN for operating such bus service which made possible to collect and provide blood on the way. He said that the provincial government would operate the bus in all districts of the province.

The bus, equipped with two beds, will reach houses of blood donors with a slogan 'One House, One Blood Donor.

Similarly, NRNA President, Dr. KC, said that the non-resident Nepalis are active in attracting investment in Nepal and their investment is more sustainable.

He said that for the prosperity of Koshi Province, the association was ready to cooperate with the NRNA in the fields of infrastructure.

Vice-president of the NRNA, Dr. Hemraj Sharma informed that the Association has done more than Rs. 1 billion in charity work since its inception.

He said that the non-resident Nepalis are active in bringing the knowledge, skills and technology learned abroad into the country.

Dr. Sharma said that the Association has been working on the areas – bringing investment in Nepal, charity works, and raising voices for the rights and interests of Nepalis living abroad.

The NRNA has prepared to transfer mobile blood buses to the Lumbini and Madhesh provinces as well.

Bin's family provided financial assistance



PHOTO: SHIVASHANKAR MISHRA/TRN

BY SHIVASHANKAR MISHRA
Bara, Jan. 17

Krishna Prasad Yadav, Province Minister for Physical Infrastructure and Development of Madhes Province, has provided Rs. 125,000 to the family of Laxmi Mukhiya Bin of Simraungadh Municipality Ward No. 1 who was killed in a firing during a protest on December 13 last year.

President of Nepali Congress Madhes Province Working Committee and Province Minister Yadav visited the Bin family on Wednesday and provided the cash amount.

Handing over the cash to the family members of the late Bin, Minister Yadav said that the province government had announced to provide additional assistance of Rs. 500,000 to the family and they would hand over the promised money soon. Laxmi Mukhiya Bin, a 25-year-old youth of Simraungadh Municipality-1, was killed when police fired to control a clash erupted between the agitating employees and police on December 13 last year.

Vice-President of Madesh Province Nepali Congress Chandra Shekhar Yadav condemned the excessive use of force, which culminated in the death of Bin.

Locals demonstrate demanding bridge construction



PHOTO: VIJAY KUMAR SAH/TRN

BY VIJAY KUMAR SAH
Dhalkebar, Jan. 17

Residents of Ichhapur, Kshireshwornath Municipality-7, Dhanusha have staged a demonstration demanding the speedy completion of the bridge over the Jalad River.

The bridge was supposed to be constructed within two and half years of the awarding of the contract, but it has been seven years since the construction has begun and work is still far from finished. So, locals held a rally on Wednesday.

The rallyists began marching from the river and blocked traffic for some time when they reached Mahendranagar Chowk. The absence of a bridge over Jalad on the Mithila Madhyama Parikrama Road has forced locals to take their life into their hands every time they cross the river.

Especially during the monsoon, the river swells up and sweeps people away.

Engineer Bibek Jha, information officer for the Division Road Office of Janakpur, blamed the contractor for delaying the bridge. He said that the company had not picked up pace despite repeated requests. Pappu Kamal JV holds the contract for the bridge.

As per the initial contract, the bridge was supposed to be completed in January 2020. But, after that deadline expired, the contractor was given till July 2023 to finish work. Five months have passed since then, yet the contractor has only reported 53 per cent progress.

When completed, the bridge will be 120 metres long and 11 metres wide. Construction cost of the bridge is expected to reach Rs. 123.5 million.

Government of Nepal
Ministry of Health & Population
Department of Health Services
Management Division
Pachali, Teku, Kathmandu, Nepal

Notice for Price bid open

Date of Notice : 18 January 2024

Pursuant to clause 31(4) and (5) of Public Procurement Regulation 2064, this is to notify all the bidders that the following substantially responsive technical bidder has been selected for further evaluation as per the Invitation for Bids published on The Rising Nepal DOHS decides to open the price bid on **2 February 2024 on 12:00** Hr.

RFB No	Notice Published Date	Successful Bidders Name and Address
DOHS/G/ICB-21/ FWD/2080-81 (Procurement of Vitamin A Capsule)	9 October 2023	**M/S Renata Limited.** Plot 1, Milk Vita Road, Sector 7, Mirpur, Dhaka, Bangladesh Dhaka Bangladesh

Nepal Electricity Authority
Transmission Directorate
Grid Development Department
132 kV Transmission Line Capacity Upgradation Project
Phone No. : +977 01-4153174, Email : griddev@nea.org.np
Date of Publication : 2080/10/04 (January18, 2024)

Opening of the Price Bids

IFB: NEA/GDD/TL-080/81-01, Up-gradation of the existing conductor of Butwal-Sunwal- New Butwal, Damuli-Bharatpur and Kusaha-Duhabi 132kV Transmission Line

This is to notify that, the technical bid of following bidder has been found substantially responsive to the requirements of the biding document and they have been determined as being qualified for award to attend the opening of the Price bid as per ITB 25.7 The Price bid shall be opened on Date, Time & Location as mentioned below in the presence of the bidder designated representatives who choose to attend.

1. M/s Sigma Con. Pvt. Ltd.

Office of Grid Development Department,
Nepal Electricity Authority, Kathmandu, Nepal
Date : February 02, 2024
Time : 12:30 PM

Government of Nepal
Ministry of Health and Population
Department of Health Services
Management Division

Request for Electronic Bids Goods

(Two-Envelope Bidding Process)

Date of Publication : 18 January 2024
Country : Nepal
Name of Project : COVID-19 Emergency Response and Health Systems Preparedness Project
Contract Title : Procurement of Fixed X-Ray 500mA With Detector
Loan No./Credit No. : 6604
RFB Reference No. : DOHS/G/ICB-14/IDA/2080-81

1. The Government of Nepal has received financing from the World Bank toward the cost of the **COVID-19 Emergency Response and Health Systems Preparedness Project** and intends to apply part of the proceeds toward payments under the contract for Procurement of Fixed X-Ray 500mA With Detector.
2. The Department of Health Services (DoHS), Management Division (MD) now invites sealed Bids from eligible Bidders for *the Procurement of Fixed X-Ray 500mA With Detector (50 Pcs) to be delivered Central Medical* Store *Teku/Pathlaiya.*
3. Bidding will be conducted through international competitive procurement using a Request for Bids (RFB) as specified in the World Bank's "Procurement Regulations for IPF Borrowers" July 2016 revised November 2020 ("Procurement Regulations") and is open to all eligible Bidders as defined in the Procurement Regulations.
4. Interested eligible Bidders may obtain further information from DoHS, MD, Teku, Kathmandu Nepal; email: dohsmdprocurement@gmail.com and inspect the bidding document during office hours, NST 10:00 hrs. to 17:00 hrs. or, may visit the URL: www.bolpatra.gov.np.
5. The bidding document in English may be obtained by downloading from PPMO's e-GP system www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp. Bidders must submit their bid electronically only and the bidders submitting their bid electronically should deposit the nonrefundable cost of bidding document NPR. 20,000.00 or USD 200.00 in the following Rajaswa (revenue) account as specified below:
   Name of the Bank : **Rastriya Banijya Bank, Teku Kathmandu**
   Name of the Office : **Department of Health Service,**
   Office Code No. : **370-013-501**
   Office Account No. : **1000100200010000**
   Revenue Head No. : **14229**
6. Pre-bid meeting shall be held at ***Meeting Hall of Management Division Department of Health Services Teku Kathmandu*** at ***12:00 Hr 16 February 2024.***
7. The bidding procedure will be single state-two envelope by e-GP system of PPMO. Electronic bids must be submitted to the office DoHS, MD, Teku, Kathmandu through the e-GP system of PPMO; www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp on or before 13:00 hrs NST of 3 March 2024. Bids received after this deadline shall be rejected.
8. The technical parts of the bids will be publicly opened in the presence of the Bidders' designated representatives and anyone who chooses to attend, at the meeting hall of DoHS, MD on 13:10 hrs NST of 3 March 2024. Financial bids will be opened after the completion of the evaluation of the technical parts of the Bids.
9. All Bids must be accompanied by a Bid Security of ***NPR. 6,500,000.00/USD. 65,000.00*** in pdf format of the original bid security, which shall be valid for the period of at least 31 July 2024.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

The only interesting answers are those that destroy the questions.
-- Susan Sontag

EDITORIAL

On Track Of Meeting SDGs

The 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, which came into force on January 1, 2016 is perhaps the most ambitious development programme agreed upon by the United Nations member states. The agenda consists of 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and 169 targets to end extreme poverty, fight inequality and deal with climate change within the period of 15 years. Considered as the shared blueprint for peace and prosperity for people and the planet, its core philosophy is that no one is left behind. The SDGs not only build on the success of the Millennium Development Goals (MDGs) but also seeks to overcome their shortcomings. The SDGs attempt to link poverty eradication efforts with the strategies that seek to enhance economic growth and address a variety of social needs such as education, health, social security, employment and environmental protection.

With the adoption of the SDGs by the global agency, the countries developed national frameworks aligning them with the policy, programmes and annual budgets to meet the stated goals. They require to do follow-up evaluation of the progress made in the implementation of the SDGs. For this, they need quality, timely and accessible data to make the real assessment of the works and gains. The national-level appraisal is important for the follow-up of SDGs execution at the global level. Nepal, committed to achieving the SDGs by 2030 has already come up with two 'Voluntary National Review (VNR) reports on the implementation status of goals. It is bracing for the third VNR and expects to finish it by the end of the current Fiscal Year 2023/24 (mid-July 2024) and submit it to the meeting of the High-Level Political Forum (HLPF) of the United Nations according to a news report of this daily published on Wednesday.

The country conducted the VNR in 2017 and 2020. The National Planning Commission (NPC) states that Nepal has so far made about 43 per cent progress in meeting the SDGs in the seven and half years. It has performed better in the field of poverty reduction, health, education, clean energy, forestry and social security, among others. Poverty has been halved and efforts are underway to reduce it by less than 5 per cent in 2030. With over 95 per cent of Nepalis having access to electricity, the country is close to meet SDG7 that stresses "affordable, reliable, sustainable and modern energy for all" by 2030. In order to effectively implement the SDGs, the country formulated and implemented 'Sustainable Development Goals for Nepal 2016-30 Roadmap' and reviewed the progress in 2022 and developed SDGs Needs Assessment, Costing and Financing Strategy, and SDGs Localisation.

Besides, the SDGs have been an important part of periodical plan, medium-term expenditure structure and annual policy and programmes and budget. The upcoming 16th Periodic Plan is being devised with an action plan to upgrade from the Least Developed Country (LDC) and achieve SDGs. To prepare the new VNR report, the NPC, the other day, organised a workshop to solicit the suggestions of the stakeholders and experts on the progress and status of the SDG implementation as well as share experiences about the good practices of other countries and ensure effective coordination and cooperation with various agencies. As the country has practiced the federal structure, it is imperative for federal, provincial and local governments to coordinate and cooperate with each other to meet the sustainable development goals.

Managing Mental Stress

PALLAV BHUSAL

In the fast-paced world of contemporary life, stress and anxiety have become undesirable companions for many. The persistent demands of work, personal responsibilities, and the constant addiction to digital connectivity can create a storm within, leaving individuals grappling with the raging waves of their thoughts and emotions. In such times, the importance of adopting a concerned and complete approach to managing stress and anxiety cannot be overstated.

It is very important to understand the origin of one's stress and learn how to manage it. Stress generally arises from the connection between demands and expectations of what one wants to achieve. There are many obligations related to work, family and society and all piles up, creating an overwhelming sense of mental pressure. Anxiety, on the other hand, often stems from a fear of the unknown or an inability to control future events.

Within stress and anxiety, overthinking serves as a consistent factor of its increment. Therefore, it is important to be mindful and pay attention to the present moment without judgment. It can be achieved through techniques including meditation and deep breathing. This helps in steering minds away from the rowdy waves of stress and anxiety. It allows for a conscious return to the present, grounding individuals in the reality of the now.

Another technique one can use to reduce stress and anxiety is by fostering meaningful connections and being social. This can be done by having simple conversations with friends, family or professional counsellors. This can help in sharing the burden of worries and provide relief. Many think that reaching out for support is a sign of weakness, but in reality, in times of distress, it is a testament to resilience and self-awareness.

Exercising is another factor that positively impacts mental resilience. The mind and body are interconnected, and nurturing physical well-being is very important. This can be achieved by exercising regularly, eating a balanced diet, and having sufficient sleep. Physical activity releases endorphins, the body's natural stress relievers, while adequate sleep and nutrition ensure the mind is equipped to handle challenges with clarity and focus.

People generally become overambitious to meet societal expectations and personal goals in a short time. Learning to set limitations, setting boundaries saying no is an art that requires practice and self-compassion. It is a demonstration of self-care and allows the individual to prioritise their well-being and allocate energy to what truly matters. Along with setting borders, one should nurture a positive mindset by reframing negative thoughts and focusing on solutions. Celebrating small victories, practising gratitude, and acknowledging personal growth can shift the narrative from one of anxiety to resilience.

Having genuine activities and craving moments of solitude can also help in reducing stress and anxiety. It can be simple things such as reading books or pursuing a hobby, or as simple as going for a morning jog, which can offer a break from external pressure. Hobbies, especially those that bring joy, act as therapeutic outlets, channelling creative energy and fostering a sense of accomplishment can help one be peacefully mindful.

Seeking help from professional guidance is also a courageous step towards self-care. Mental health professionals provide tools and strategies tailored to individual needs, offering a supportive framework for navigating the complexities of the mind. In today's lifestyle, stress and anxiety are inevitable mazes, but how we get out of them is within our control. As discussed, by embracing mindfulness, fostering connections, prioritising physical well-being, setting boundaries, cultivating a positive mindset, enjoying moments of solitude, and seeking professional guidance when needed, individuals can balance life, stress and anxiety.

Ensure Justice To Conflict Victims

Dr. Balmukunda Regmi



In last hundred years, Nepal has undergone a series of historical political and social changes. Killings and martyrdoms took place before or during all revolutions, but it was after 1996 when the Maoists took arms against the existing political system that took the lives of thousands of people. Those who died include armed and unarmed persons, those who sided with the government, supported the rebels, or remained neutral. Many became orphan, heirless, helpless, isolated, physically handicapped and mentally shattered. Many went missing, their status and fate unknown, leaving their relatives restless over the whereabouts of the loved ones.

Identifying the autocratic monarchy as the common enemy, the then armed CPN (Maoist) and the weakened seven political parties signed a 12-point New Delhi agreement on 20th November 2005, opening the way for a solution to the decade-old armed conflict that ultimately led to the formation of federal, democratic and republican system. They worked together to push nationwide democratic movement, focusing their assault against the monarchy from their respective positions.

Justice delayed

Signing the Comprehensive Peace Accord with the then government, the CPN (Maoist) agreed to give up the arms and become a part of the mainstream politics in 2006, slating the roadmap to peace. However, new issues and conflicts continued to surface. Peace was time and again disturbed by various agitations launched in the name of identities, ethnicities and regions. After many agreements and settlements, Nepal still faces sporadic eruptions of unrests fuelled by one or another slogan.

As decided by the 12-point agreement, the Maoists armed force and the Nepal Army were put under the UN in Nepal (UNMIN) supervision during the process of the election of Constituent Assembly. It was only in 2010, Nepal Government made a bold decision not to extend the UNMIN mandate, the later withdrew in 2011. This completed the settlement of the parties and the armies as a whole. While issues of transitional justice, human rights violations and compensations to the victims were frequently discussed, it was only in 2014 both sides realised it necessary to find out and publish the incidents of the grave violation of human rights committed in the course of the decade-long armed conflict.

They wanted to create an environment conducive for sustainable peace by enhancing spirit of mutual good faith and tolerance in the society for reconciliation, reparation to the victims, and legal actions against those involved in the serious offences. This resulted in the enactment of The Enforced Disappearances Inquiry, Truth and Reconciliation Commission Act, 2014. The next year in 2015, the Truth and Reconciliation Commission was formed to investigate on the cases of human rights violations and crimes against humanity, and to create enabling environment for social reconciliation.

Similarly, need for the investigation on the enforced disappeared persons during the armed conflict and bringing the real facts to the public, compensation and reliefs to the victims, legal sanctions against the perpetrators, was strongly felt. As a result, the country enacted The Commission for Investigation, Verification, and Reconciliation of Disappeared Persons Act in 2014, and formed the Commission in 2015. The Commission was also to address the underlying causes of armed conflict and the measures related to political, legal, institutional, administrative and practical reforms to establish sustainable peace and protect the country from such type of armed conflict in future.

> The victims, irrespective of their political affiliation, or the circumstance under which they fell victim, should be provided justice and compensations.

However, despite their sincere efforts, the above Commissions could not proceed smoothly with their tasks. Many victims have already died, justice declined. A child born orphan is now grown up and has become a voter. Further delay in addressing the painful issues only worsens the situation. At personal level some wrongdoers may escape due punishments, but at the national and societal levels, hatred against each other will deepen. Denials of timely just punishments, reconciliations and compensations lead to frustrations, fears and hatreds, which in turn can be exploited by destabilizers, giving false assurances of justice. Thus, delays in justice and prolongations of the transition can create lawlessness, damage social harmony and harm the national interests.

There are already signs of such risks. Not only the governments and the ruling parties, also the opposition parties and independent nationalist forces have become the targets of different types of agitators. See how an army man in UN peace keeping mission was arrested and tried in the UK. See how some people have threatened to sue Nepali leaders and marched to The Hague. See how the mainstream parties were physically attacked during their political activities. See how two sitting prime ministers have been attacked for observing their traditional religious and cultural practices, and see how divisive, hate speeches are being fired by officiating leaders against the gentle peace-loving Nepalis and their religions, cultures and practices. The present situation calls for immediate cooperation among all nationalist forces, ruling and opposition, a signatory of the 12-point agreement or not, in bringing the truth and reconciliation process to a just end.

Limits

Armed conflicts are armed conflicts. Killings take place in such scenarios. But there are limits the warring parties should not cross. Disregarding their political faith, the persons who have committed the grave violation of the human rights must be punished. Perpetrators who committed crimes such as killings after surrender, intentional armed attack against unarmed enemy and persons not in mission, rape, ethnic cleansing, should not be pardoned even with the consent of the victims or their representatives. The victims, irrespective of their political affiliation, or the circumstance under which they fell victim, should be provided justice and compensations.

As to those who committed crimes but not indicted with the grave violation of human rights, reconciliation should be sought, and can be pardoned if the victim agrees to. In case an agreement could not be reached between the victim and the wrongdoer, the victim can go to the court, with the government providing free legal services to them. What if international bodies do not agree on our principles and settlements? Let us politely explain our views. If we have national consensus on the issue but have differences with international bodies, we can go with the domestic lines. If we are divided, pass our proposal with two-thirds majority of both Houses of federal parliament, separately. In case such endorsement could not be reached, put to plebiscite.

(Regmi is a professor at Tribhuvan University and a researcher at Charhar Institute, China)

Pathways To Fruitful Negotiation

Mukti Rijal



This writer has browsed some of the books on negotiation and conflict resolution authored by William Ury-one fo the world's influential experts on negotiation and conflict mediation. He is the co-author of *Getting to Yes, Negotiating Agreement without Giving* In - the world's all-time bestselling book on negotiation with more than 15 million copies sold and translated into more than thirty five languages. This book has been translated into Nepali as well and this columnist, senior advocate Matrika Niraula, among others, were the co-translators of the book in Nepali. The great thinker of our time late John Kenneth Galbraith appreciated the book saying "this is by far the best book I have ever read about negotiation. It is equally relevant for the individual who would like to keep his friends, property and income and statesman who would like to keep peace."

William Ury has been a co-founder of Harvard's Programme on Negotiation (PoN). Harvard's prestigious and renowned Programme had availed its expertise to facilitate dialogue among the political functionaries and critical opinion makers immediately after the comprehensive peace accord to quell enmity and settle the underlying issues of the ten-year-long armed conflict in Nepal. Credit goes to Dr. Poorna Kant Adhikari and Bishnu Bhusal for coordinating and organising such events in Nepal. William Ury has devoted his life to help people, organisations, and nations transform conflicts around the world. He has provided his expertise as a negotiator in many of the toughest disputes of our times. He has served as a negotiation adviser and mediator in conflicts ranging from US partisan battles to wars in the Middle East, Colombia, Korea, and Ukraine.

Different jurisdictions

Getting to Yes that William Ury co-authored with late Roger Fisher lent important ideas and won quick popularity in this country too. Today, it has been used as a key handy material in conflict mediation and negotiation trainings in different jurisdictions across the world. . The core messages in *Getting to Yes* constitute the widely appreciated fundamentals of the curriculum for mediation training defined and standardised, among others, by Mediation Council – the regulatory and accrediting authority for mediation embodied in the mediation act of Nepal. Needless to say, the core tips undergirding *Getting to Yes* include as to how to separate the people from the problems, focus on interests not positions, work together to create options that satisfy disputing parties and negotiate successfully with people or parties who are more powerful and refuse to play by the rules or resort to dirty tricks.

In the same way, another popular book by William Ury which is used as a practical guide in negotiation is *Getting Past No,* which offers a proven breakthrough strategy for turning adversaries into negotiating partners. The book fills with practically tested tips to deal with tough times, tough people, and tough negotiations. In this book, he offers key messages to secure what is known as breakthrough negotiation especially in intractable conflicts. Breakthrough negotiation,

> Rather than telling the adversary what to do it is better to let them figure it out by themselves.

according to Ury, is the opposite of imposing one's own position on the other side.

Rather than pounding in a new idea from the outside, it is effective to encourage the adversary to reach for it from within. Rather than telling the adversary what to do it is better to let them figure it out by themselves. Rather than pressuring the adversary to change their mind, it is better to create an environment in which the adversary can learn and break through their own resistance. He writes further "the adversary's resistance to joint problem solving stems from such barriers as anger, negative emotions and so on. Ury advises that to engage in joint problem solving, it is necessary to gain mental balance and stay focused on achieving on what is intended.

Likewise, Ury has, of late, authored two seminal books that carry titles *Getting to Yes with Yourself* and *Path to possible to thrive in age of conflict.* In our homes, workplaces, and around the world, devastating disagreements are poisoning our relationships and paralysing our ability to discuss critical issues. But conflict doesn't have to be negative and destructive. In fact, Ury demonstrates how constructive conflict negotiation can open up a world of possibilities. In his book *Path to Possible*, Ury defines actionable new framework to approach conflict with curiosity, creativity and collaboration.

True needs

In his yet another book *Getting to Yes With Yourself*, Ury has pointed out that the great impediments to successful agreements and productive relationships is actually the person himself or herself. The natural tendency that every one of us possesses is to react in ways that does not serve our true needs and interests. He emphasises on the need first to learn to understand and influence oneself. This can then contributes to lay ground work for understanding and influencing others in resolving disputes. In this book William Ury draws on his personal and professional experiences from negotiating conflicts around the world to present a practical method to help the person to get yes to oneself significantly improving ones own ability to get to yes with others.

In fact, according to Ury, *Getting to Yes with Yourself* prepares the way for getting to yes with others. The famous book, referred at the onset of this article and widely used as a seminal resource material on conflict negotiation, is about changing the outer game of negotiation, while *Getting to Yes with Yourself* is about changing the inner game so that outer game can be changed. According to Ury, human being are reaction machines. It is only natural to blame others and reject when rejected. However, getting to yes oneself may be challenging but it is most rewarding in negotiating settlement of conflicts. These conflict negotiation literatures are very useful in the wider contexts of federal Nepal where conflicts occur in public and private realm.

(The author is presently associated with Policy Research Institute (PRI) as a senior research fellow. rijalmukti@gmail.com)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 18, 1974

Sugar Confiscated

Banepa, Jan.17: The local police have confiscated eight bags of sugar brought here by Mr. Hari Bhakta Dhaubael without coupon, reports RSS

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

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Please email your contributions to:

trnfeatures@hotmail.com
trnfeatures@gmail.com

Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Cope With Threat Of Cold



I am writing in response to a news report titled "*Cold wave affects life across Tarai*" which was published on January 13, 2024 in this daily. The winter season is at its peak in the Northern Hemisphere. And people throughout Nepal are experiencing the adverse impact of the cold. Especially the Tarai region of Nepal tends to get cold waves.

It is the elderly, children, the infirm, and poor citizens who are the most hit by the cold waves. During such cold waves, schools are closed, daily activities are hampered and number of people seeking government services is reduced. Instead, people prefer to remain at home in front of heaters to keep themselves warm. However, not all can afford a heater, which is why it is the poor and impoverished people who are the most adversely affected. Nepal government should ensure that warm clothes are available to the poor citizens who often are vulnerable to the cold waves during the winter.

Santosh Joshi
Kanchanpur

TAILPIECE

A juggler, driving to his next performance, is stopped by the police. "What are these matches and lighter fluid doing in your car?" asks the cop.

"I'm a juggler and I juggle flaming torches in my act."

"Oh yeah?" says the doubtful cop. "Let's see you do it." The juggler gets out and starts juggling the blazing torches masterfully.

A couple driving by slows down to watch. "Wow," says the driver to his wife. "I'm glad I quit drinking. Look at the test they're giving now!"

After spending all day Sunday watching football on television, a man fell asleep and spent the night in the chair.

His wife woke him in the morning. "It's twenty to seven," she called.

"Blimey, who scored twenty?"

Multiple deaths feared as fireworks factory explodes in Thailand

AP
Bangkok, Jan. 17

An explosion at a fireworks factory in central Thailand killed at least 20 people on Wednesday, the government's disaster relief agency said.

People were also injured in the incident, the Department of Disaster Prevention and Mitigation said, but it did not say how many. Officials were working to secure the site in Suphan Buri province and help people who were impacted, it said. The cause of explosion was being investigated.

Suphan Buri is about 95 kilometres (60 miles) northwest of Bangkok, in the heart of Thailand's central rice-growing region.

The office of Prime Minister Srettha Thavisin, who is in Switzerland for the World Economic Forum, distributed a video showing him being told over the phone by the regional police commander that there were 20 to 30 workers at the factory at the time of the explosion and that none of them could be found.

Kritsada Manee-In, a rescue worker with the Samerkun Suphan Buri Rescue Foundation, who earlier estimated that around 15 to 17 people had been killed, said an exact count was difficult because the bodies were in pieces.

Photos posted on social media showed a thick plume of black smoke rising over the scene of the blast in an otherwise unoccupied rice field. Photos posted online by local rescue workers showed the factory site virtually levelled flat aside from debris and body parts.

National police chief Torsak Sukvimol confirmed local news reports that there had been another explosion at the factory in November last year that killed one worker and seriously injured three others.

He said police would pursue legal action for any wrongdoing involved.

The blast, whose cause was not immediately clear, came less than a month before Chinese New Year in February, when demand for fireworks is strong.

In July last year, a large explosion at a fireworks warehouse in southern Thailand killed at least 10 people and wounded more than 100, according to officials.

That explosion in Narathiwat province was in a residential area and damaged about 100 houses within a 500-meter (1,640-foot) radius, according to the Department of Disaster Prevention and Mitigation.

The Narathiwat governor said that blast was likely ignited by construction work in the warehouse, with sparks from metal welding causing the fireworks stored inside to catch fire and explode.

Qatar, France send medicine for hostages in Gaza

AP
Rafah, Gaza Strip, Jan. 17



PHOTO: AP

Palestinians walk through destruction by the Israeli bombardment in the Nusseirat refugee camp in Gaza Strip, Tuesday, Jan. 16, 2024.

A shipment of medicine for dozens of hostages held by Hamas was en route to Gaza on Wednesday after France and Qatar mediated the first agreement between Israel and the militant group since a weeklong cease-fire in November.

The medicines arrived in Egypt and were to be delivered to the International Committee of the Red Cross, which will then hand them over to Hamas. Qatar said the deal also includes the delivery of additional medicine and humanitarian aid to Palestinians in the besieged coastal enclave.

The deal came more than 100 days into a conflict that shows no sign of ending and which has sparked tensions across the Middle East, with a dizzying array of strikes and counterstrikes in recent days from northern Iraq to the Red Sea and from southern Lebanon to Pakistan.

In Gaza, Palestinian militants are still putting up resistance across the narrow coastal strip in the face of one of the deadliest military campaigns in recent history. Some 85% of the territory's population of 2.3 million people have fled their homes and the United Nations says a quarter of the population is starving.

Israel has vowed to dismantle Hamas' military and governing abilities to ensure that it can never repeat the Oct. 7 attack that triggered the war. Militants burst through Israel's border defenses and stormed through several communities, killing some 1,200 people, mostly civilians, and capturing around 250.

Israel has also vowed to return the more than 100 hostages still held inside Gaza after Hamas released most of the rest in November in exchange for Palestinians imprisoned in Israel. Israel says only military pressure will bring about the release of more captives, but as the fighting grinds on they are at increased risk of being killed in Israeli strikes or during rescue operations.

Hamas has said it will not release any more hostages until there is a permanent cease-fire, something Israel and the United States, its top ally, have ruled out.

In just the past few days, a U.S.-led coalition has carried out strikes against Iran-backed Houthi rebels in Yemen; Iran has struck what it described as an Israeli spy headquarters in northern Iraq and anti-Iran militants in Pakistan and Syria; and Israel and Lebanon's Hezbollah have escalated the intensity of their fighting across the border.

Iran's militant allies across the region say they are striking U.S. and Israeli targets to pressure them to halt the Gaza offensive. Iran itself has encouraged the attacks while avoiding direct involvement, but appeared to be flexing its muscles with the strikes in Syria and Pakistan.

PAKISTAN RECALLS ENVOY TO IRAN OVER AIR STRIKE

AP
Islamabad, Jan. 17

Pakistan recalled its ambassador to Tehran on Wednesday, a day after Iran launched airstrikes on Pakistan that it claimed targeted bases for a militant Sunni separatist group. Islamabad angrily denounced the attack as a "blatant violation" of its airspace and said it killed two children.

Tuesday's strike on Pakistan's restive south-western Baluchistan province imperilled diplomatic relations between the two neighbours, but both sides appeared wary of provoking the other. Iran and nuclear-armed Pakistan have long regarded each other with suspicion over militant attacks. The attack also threatened to further ignite violence in a Middle East unsettled by Israel's ongoing war on Hamas in the Gaza Strip. Iran launched strikes late Monday in Iraq and Syria over an Islamic State-claimed suicide bombing that killed over 90 people earlier this month.

Mumtaz Zahra Baloch, the spokesperson for Pakistan's Ministry of Foreign Affairs, announced that Islamabad is recalling the country's ambassador to Iran over the previous day's strikes.

In her televised remarks, she said "last night's unprovoked and blatant breach of Pakistan's sovereignty by Iran is a violation of international law and the purposes and principles of the Charter of the United Nations."

Israel strikes kill seven in West Bank



PHOTO: AFP

Palestinian onlookers survey the mangled wreckage of a car hit by an Israeli air strike targeting a top militant near Balata refugee camp in the occupied West Bank.

AFP
Tulkarem (Palestinian Territories), Jan. 17

Israeli strikes killed seven people near two refugee camps in the occupied West Bank on Wednesday, emergency services and the army said, as violence in the territory sees no let-up

The Palestinian Red Crescent said an Israeli strike killed four people inside Tulkarem camp early in the morning.

"Palestine Red Crescent teams transport four martyrs from inside Tulkarem camp due to the occupation's bombardment," the group said in a statement.

An official at the camp confirmed the strike and the death toll.

"The camp is besieged by aircraft and heavy numbers of the Israeli army, and tanks," Faisal Salama told AFP.

In a separate strike near Balata refugee camp, east of the city of Nablus, Palestinian official news agency Wafa reported that three men were killed.

The army said Ahmed Abdullah Abu Shalal, a Palestinian militant, had been killed, averting a "terrorist attack" he was planning.

Palestinian onlookers survey the mangled wreckage of a car hit by an Israeli air strike targeting a top militant near Balata refugee camp in the occupied West Bank © Zain JAAFAR / AFP

Abu Shalal had been responsible for a "number of terrorist attacks" over the past year, including one in annexed east Jerusalem, the army said.

It said he was killed following intelligence "of his cell's intentions of carrying out an imminent terrorist attack".

Camp resident Sajed Hazeem said he was woken at dawn by a loud explosion.

Minutes after the blast an ambulance arrived at the scene but its access to the car was blocked by Israeli troops who arrived at the same time, Hazeem said.

"The army pulled out the bodies and after about half an hour it withdrew," Hazeen told AFP.

The Palestinian health ministry in Ramallah said the body of an "unidentified martyr killed by the occupation (Israel) in a bombing of a vehicle" had been received by a hospital in Nablus.

An AFP correspondent saw a pile of debris and the mangled remains of a car that was hit.

Since the start of the Israel-Hamas war in Gaza on October 7, the West Bank has experienced a level of violence not seen since the second Palestinian uprising or intifada between 2000 and 2005.

Israeli army raids and attacks by settlers have killed at least 353 people in the territory, according to an AFP tally based on sources from both sides.

Israel has occupied the West Bank, home to about three million Palestinians, since the Six-Day War of 1967.

Excluding annexed east Jerusalem, the territory is home to around 490,000 Israelis who live in settlements considered illegal under international law.

PRISM

Snow shark sculpture attracts tourists

Iowa: An Iowa man's yard is attracting schools of visitors from across the area after he built a 20-foot-long shark sculpture out of snow.

Carlos Maldonado, a sculptor and owner of Carlos Maldonado Artwork in Iowa City, created the 5.5-foot-tall great white shark sculpture from snow with help from his two sons.

"I looked up snow sculptures, I didn't really want to do anything plain," Maldonado told Iowa's News Now. "When I saw a shark online, I figured I could do that. So, I gave it shot and this is what we ended up with."

He said it took about 4 1/2 hours to sculpt the shark and another hour and a half to colour it with watered-down acrylic paint the following day.

Maldonado's photos of his artwork posted online led to an influx of visitors wanting to take photos with the snow shark.

Dog rescued from freezing river

Michigan: Firefighters in Michigan came to the rescue of a 6-year-old Irish setter who fell through the ice of a frozen river.

The M-20 Animal Hospital in Midland said the Midland Fire Department was called when the dog, named Koufax, went for a deer chase at Emerson Park and ended up falling through the ice covering the Tittabawassee River.

"His owner made the wise choice to call 911 instead of trying to rescue him," the animal hospital said in a Facebook post. "Responders were there in 10 minutes and rescued Koufax from the freezing water."

The canine was initially cold and unresponsive, but veterinarians were able to bring his temperature up after about two hours.

"Koufax is now home resting," the animal hospital said.

(Agencies)

NKorea's rejection of South is both shock, inevitable

AP
Seoul, South Korea, Jan. 17

Even for a nation that has perfected the provocative, North Korean leader Kim Jong Un's declaration that he would abandon the existential goal of reconciling with rival South Korea was a shock. But a closer look shows it's the almost inevitable culmination of years of building tension.

World powers will now be closely watching to see how one of Kim's biggest foreign policy declarations since he took power in 2011 plays out as he works to gain leverage in a region that holds both promise and danger for his small, impoverished, nuclear-armed nation.

The bombshell came at this week's rubber-stamp parliament, where Kim called for rewriting North Korea's constitution to eliminate the idea of a peaceful unification between the war-divided countries and to cement the South as an "invariable principal enemy."

It's the clearest sign yet of how far inter-Korean relations have fallen since February 2019, when Kim's nuclear diplomacy with former U.S. President Donald Trump imploded in Hanoi, Vietnam. The animosity that followed that highly public setback has been accompanied by an accelerated, and unprecedented, expansion of Kim's nuclear arsenal and by repeated threats of nuclear war against Washington and Seoul.

Kim, who during Monday's Supreme People's Assembly meeting described South Korea as "top-class stooges" of America, may be attempting to diminish South Korea's regional power while moving toward direct U.S.-North Korean nuclear talks.

Kim's new approach to the South comes as he tries to break out of diplomatic isolation and strengthen his footing regionally. He is playing off deepening U.S. tensions with Moscow and Beijing over Russia's war in Ukraine and China's assertive foreign policy.

North Korea's recent efforts to boost ties with Russia and China and join a united front against Washington in what Kim calls a "new Cold War" were highlighted by his September visit to Russia for a summit with Russian President Vladimir Putin.

North Korea has been recalibrating its regional approach since the collapse of the 2019 Hanoi summit, said Ankit Panda, an expert with the Carnegie Endowment for International Peace.



FILE PHOTO: AP

U.S. B-52H bombers, centre, and F-16 fighter jets and South Korean Air Force F-35A fighter jets, right bottom, fly over the Korean Peninsula during a joint air drill in South Korea on April 14, 2023.

North Korea no longer sees Seoul as a useful middleman to extract concessions from Washington. Instead, its rival is now seen as an obstacle to the North's efforts to carve out a more assertive presence in global affairs, said Hong Min, an analyst at South Korea's Institute for National Unification.

Pyongyang has viciously criticized conservative President Yoon Suk Yeol, who since taking office in 2022 has expanded military cooperation with Washington and Tokyo while seeking stronger U.S. assurances that it would swiftly and decisively use its nuclear capabilities to defend its ally in the event of a North Korean nuclear attack.

In eliminating the idea of a shared sense of statehood between the Koreas, Kim could be reinforcing North Korea's older approach of ignoring South Korea and attempting direct dealings with Washington. The old reasoning in Pyongyang, according to Hong, was that the South wasn't a direct party to the armistice that ended the bloodshed of the 1950-53 Korean War. That ceasefire was signed between the U.S.-led U.N. Command, North Korea and China, which sent troops to fight for the North.

Declaring the South as a permanent adversary, not as a potential partner for reconciliation, could also be aimed at improving the credibility of Kim's escalatory nuclear doctrine, which authorizes the military to launch preemptive nuclear attacks against adversaries if the leadership is under threat, Hong said.

An intensifying campaign to eliminate South Korean cultural influences and to reinforce the North's separate identity may be aimed at strengthening the Kim family's dynastic rule.

At the assembly, Kim ordered his country to remove past symbols of inter-Korean reconciliation, including a cross-border railway section and a unification monument in Pyongyang he described as an "eyesore," and to "completely eliminate such concepts as 'reunification,' 'reconciliation' and 'fellow countrymen' from the national history of our republic."

TODAY IN HISTORY

474 – Seven-year-old Leo II succeeds his maternal grandfather Leo I as Byzantine emperor. He dies ten months later.
532 – Nika riots in Constantinople fail.
1126 – Emperor Huizong abdicates the Chinese throne in favour of his son Emperor Qinzong.
1670 – Henry Morgan captures Panama.
1701 – Frederick I crowns himself King of Prussia in Königsberg.
1788 – The first elements of the First Fleet carrying 736 convicts from Great Britain to Australia arrive at Botany Bay.
1806 – Jan Willem Janssens surrenders the Dutch Cape Colony to the British.
1866 – Wesley College is established in Melbourne, Australia.
1886 – Modern field hockey is born with the formation of The Hockey Association in England.
1896 – An X-ray generating machine is exhibited for the first time by H. L. Smith.



PHOTO: KABIN ADHIKARI/TRN

Construction works underway on Bishnumati corridor from Gongabu Buspark to Tokha area in Kathmandu on Wednesday.

ADB, Pokhara sign deal for tourism development

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Lekhnath, Jan. 17

The Asian Development Bank (ADB) and Pokhara Metropolitan City have signed an agreement to provide financial support of Rs. 4.5 billion for the projects related to sustainable tourism development and life improvement.

This deal is the part of the agreement signed between the Government of Nepal and the ADB for a concessional loan of US$ 160 million and grant worth US$ 6 million.

Finance Secretary Dr. Krishna Hari Pushkar and ADB's Country Director for Nepal, Arnaud Cauchois signed the agreement at a programme organised at the Ministry of Finance in Kathmandu.

Likewise, the agreement related to the project of sustainable tourism development has been signed by project leader of the ADB, Roshan Kumar Shrestha and Dhana Raj Acharya and Shyam Krishna Thapa, Mayor and Chief Administrative Officer of Pokhara Metropolis respectively.

According to Acharya, the construction of a fast track from Pokhara International Airport to Lakeside, development of Panchase area, construction of cycle trail connecting seven lakes, establishment of a botanical garden, establishment and operation of disaster management unit in Lekhnath area, and construction of Firke corridor are included in the project.

This deal is the part of the agreement signed between the Government of Nepal and the ADB for a concessional loan of US$ 160 million and grant worth US$ 6 million.

He expressed his belief that the project would contribute significantly to the overall development of Pokhara. "We are soon going to declare Pokhara as the capital of tourism, in this context we are holding discussions and dialogues with various agencies of the federal government as well," said Acharya, "The agreement of the project related to sustainable tourism development and life improvement proves to be a cornerstone for the overall development of Pokhara and turning it as a tourism capital."

He has promised that all kinds of support and facilitation will be provided by the Metropolitan City for the implementation of the agreement. Pokhara will establish a separate project office for the implementation of the project.

City Development Fund will be a partner in the project operation. Under this, the cost of 15 different projects has been estimated at Rs. 7.55 billion, but in the first phase, an agreement worth Rs. 4.55 billion has been reached.

High mountainous areas receive rain, snow

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 17

High hilly and mountainous areas from Dolpa in the west to Ilam in the east received good rainfall and snowfall on Tuesday and Wednesday.

But the Kathmandu Valley did not receive any rainfall although the meteorologist on Tuesday predicted that the Kathmandu Valley would receive rainfall on Wednesday.

According to climate analyst Ujjwal Upadhyay, the likelihood of rainfall was high on Wednesday, but the moisture predominantly shifted towards Dolakha and Ramechhap, resulting in substantial precipitation in those areas.

Around 80 per cent of the rainfall was concentrated in mountainous regions spanning from Dolpa and Mustang to Ilam. Only Tokha in Kathmandu received rainfall on Tuesday, according to Upadhyay.

As the surrounding hills received snowfall, Kathmandu is likely to witness a temperature drop for a few days, he added.

Upadhyay further added, "There is now no forecasted rainfall in Kathmandu for at least the next 10 days. This winter will likely end without any precipitation." However, according to Upadhaya, the high hilly areas from Dolpa to Ilam received good rainfall on Tuesday and Wednesday.

Rojan Lamichhane, meteorologist of the Department of Hydrology and Meteorology, said that the sky would remain cloudy on Thursday as well but there was no chance of rainfall for another few days in Kathmandu.

He said that the snowfall in the mountainous areas of Koshi, Gandaki and Karnali Provinces would lead to a cold situation in the lowland areas.

On Wednesday, the temperature in Kathmandu was recorded at 4.5 degrees Celsius.

Meanwhile, the high mountainous area in Ramechhap received the first snow of this winter.

The farmers who were worried in the lack of snow even by the end of December have become happy after Tuesday's snowfall.

According to our Ramechhap correspondent, Sailung, Chhangetir and other areas received snow on Tuesday and Wednesday.

After the Kalinchowk area in Dolakha received snow on Tuesday, many people from Dolakha and even Kathmandu reached the area to play with the snow.

Respiratory infections surge in Europe: WHO

XINHUA
Copenhagen, Jan. 17

A leading World Health Organization (WHO) official on Tuesday called for vigilance in the face of rising cases of respiratory diseases in Europe.

Hans Henri P. Kluge, the WHO's regional director for Europe, noted a surge in influenza infections and hospitalizations at a press conference in Copenhagen, and urged health systems to prepare for a likely increase in cases in the coming weeks.

The Netherlands is currently grappling with an upswing in respiratory infections, according to the National Institute for Public Health and the Environment (RIVM).

Various pathogens, including COVID-19, influenza virus and seasonal coronavirus are "now common" among the population, the RIVM said in its most recent update as of Jan. 10.

The number of individuals reporting flu-like symptoms is on the rise, it said. In the past week, 44 out of 100,000 people sought medical attention for such complaints, marking a notable increase from the previous week's 27 per 100,000.

Recent data also reveals a surge in influenza virus cases, with almost 35 percent of samples from individuals reporting flu-like symptoms testing positive, compared to the previous week's 13 percent, according to RIVM.

In Italy, hospitals were under intense pressure due to the worst flu wave the country had witnessed in at least 15 years, Italian health professionals warned last Friday.

Admissions to emergency rooms increased by 20 percent to 30 percent last week, mainly due to serious flu cases, according to the Italian Federation of Health Authorities and Hospitals (FIASO).

In another development, the Spanish government reimposed the mandatory use of facemasks in hospitals and health centers as of Jan. 10, following a sharp rise in COVID-19 and flu infections since the start of the new year.

Spain reported a sharp rise in respiratory illnesses, with the infection rate soaring to over 952 cases per 100,000 inhabitants. The peak of infections was set to arrive, Health Minister Monica Garcia warned last week.

At a press conference in Copenhagen Tuesday, Kluge said that vulnerable populations must be kept up-to-date with their COVID-19 and influenza vaccinations. He also underlined the critical success of COVID-19 vaccines since their introduction in December 2020.

Bagmati govt to build open space for demonstration

BY RAM MANI DAHAL
Hetauda, Jan. 17

The Bagmati Province government has announced the construction of one open space for public demonstration in each of the 13 districts of the province to enhance democracy.

The process to prepare the open space for public demonstration is going to begin under the Ministry of Internal Affairs and Law of the Bagmati Province.

Bagmati Province Minister for Internal Affairs and Law Ganga Narayan Shrestha said that in the first phase, one demonstration space will be established in each 13 districts of the province.

Minister Shrestha, who is also the Spokesperson for the Provincial Government, said that the spaces would be constructed at a cost of Rs. 200,000 each in the Fiscal Year 2023/2024.

He said that the concept of the public demonstration space was introduced to control and manage the threats posed by protests, especially in the urban areas like Kathmandu, causing property damage and significant traffic issues.

To address the organised nature of protests and maintain control, the Bagmati Province government has conceptualised the construction of public demonstration venues. Minister Shrestha stated that the purpose was to provide a designated space for citizens to express their dissent publicly, ensuring order and management during protests.

Minister Shrestha expressed confidence that the initiative would contribute to refining and tempering the culture of protests and cooperation in preserving the sanctity of demonstrations.



Minister Ganga Narayan Shrestha

The provincial government will decide whether to continue the programme in the coming year based on its needs and justification. The provincial government has said that it is going to manage the protest site to ensure the freedom of expression of citizens and to protect public property.

Saud stresses...

He also said that while on one hand, the world is grappling with pandemic, poverty and hunger, but on the other, arms races continue to rise, and so does global military expenditure, on the other hand, human-induced climate catastrophes are creating havoc in the world.

The combined effect of these multiple and intersecting problems has badly impacted developing countries, particularly poor and vulnerable ones, disproportionately, according to him.

He also said that Nepal always conducted independent, objective, balanced, and non-aligned foreign policy, and it never joined any military alliance and never accepted to be a part of the security pact of any country.

'Make academic programmes...

According to her, the government was preparing to implement 'Digital Nepal Framework' to ensure every citizen's access to IT. She stressed the need for connecting all academic subjects to IT. She assured that the government would provide scholarships for IT students in the upcoming budget and shared that a law to regulate social media would be introduced within 2080 BS.

As per the agreement inked on Wednesday, 30 students selected on the basis on competition among the students studying in the 7th semester of Masters in IT will be taught the commercial course of the Microsoft Company.

Samir Thapa, Director of Date and AI at Microsoft Company in the USA, facilitated this, it was shared. Department Chief Sayami said the selected 30 students would get jobs at home and abroad in the related field upon the completion of their study.

Choplal Bhusal, Officiating Vice-Chancellor of the University, emphasised optimal utilisation of the theoretical and practical knowledge provided in the University.

Addressing the programme virtually, Microsoft's Thapa shared that the collaboration was initiated to those aspiring to build a respectable career in the related field in the USA.

According to him, many of the IT graduates from Nepal in the USA were compelled to do menial jobs in a lack of proper synergy between the academic programmes of the University and the needs of the IT sector.

Waterbirds decline in...

And the current bird population has significantly decreased compared to the past."

A total of 162 bird species inhabit the water areas of Nepal, with 41 species identified in the Narayani River area this year. Out of the overall avian population in Nepal, over 200 species are reliant on water, including 100 species categorized as visiting birds.

During winter, visiting birds seek refuge in wetlands near rivers. Wetlands, often referred to as the kidneys of nature, are currently facing a crisis due to recent destruction.

In East Nawalparasi, bird counting was conducted in four groups, covering the areas from Sighrauli Golaghat to Amaltari, Sighrauli to Pitholi, Pitholi to Amaltari, and Amaltari to Triveni Gandak Barrage.

Every year, visiting birds from Siberia, China, Russia, Mongolia, Thailand, Korea, Burma, and other countries migrate to the Narayani River and its surrounding areas during this time. As a result, bird counting activities are conducted in the Narayani River region annually to monitor their presence.

The global bird census, initiated in 1967, commenced in Nepal in 1987. Since the same year, bird counting activities also began in the Chitwan National Park area. Concurrently, Tiger Tops Tharu Village and the Jatayu Restaurant Management Committee have been organising an annual bird count in the Chitwan National Park, West Sector, and East Nawalparasi, as mentioned by Tiger Tops manager Bhagirath Chaudhary.

Chaudhary said that the primary challenges contributing to the decline in the number of indigenous birds in the Narayani River and wetlands, including the park, are habitat loss, the absence of a comprehensive protection plan from relevant agencies, and illegal poaching.

Modi's promised Ram temple is set to open

AP
New Delhi, Jan. 17

Frenzied preparations were underway Wednesday in India's northern holy city of Ayodhya to mark the opening of a grand temple for Lord Ram, Hinduism's most revered deity.

The Ram Mandir's opening Monday would fulfill a decadeslong Hindu nationalist pledge that is expected to resonate with voters during the upcoming national election expected in April or May.

Several sprawling tent cities were being erected nearby to accommodate tens of thousands of devotees who are expected to attend. Dozens of private jets will fly India's powerful elite, including top industrialists, movie stars and celebrities, to Ayodhya to see the ceremony. Prime Minister Narendra Modi's government has planned live screenings across the country, as well as at some Indian embassies across the world.

Modi will be in attendance, alongside several Hindu priests, for the consecration ceremony in which a statue of Ram is to be placed in the temple's inner sanctum.

Modi's ruling Hindu nationalist Bharatiya Janata Party has long campaigned for the temple to replace the 16th-century Babri Mosque that was demolished by Hindu mobs in 1992, sparking nationwide riots that killed more than 2,000 people, mostly Muslims. The decadeslong dispute ended in 2019 when, in a controversial decision, India's Supreme Court granted the site to Hindus and gave a different plot of land to Muslims for a mosque.



PHOTO: AP

A construction crew works on Ram Mandir, a Hindu temple dedicated to Lord Ram in Ayodhya, India on Tuesday.

The temple's opening at one of India's most contentious religious sites ahead of the national polls scheduled for the spring is expected to give major momentum to Modi as he looks to extend his rule for a record third-consecutive term by drawing on the religious sentiments of Hindus, who make up about 80% of India's population.

The temple, a three-story structure clad in pink sandstone, stretches across 2.9 hectares (7.2 acres) in a 28-hectare (70-acre) complex. It will have a 1.3-meter (4.25-foot) idol of Lord Ram, whom Hindus believe was born at the exact site where the razed mosque once stood.

The city, once dotted with tightly packed houses and rundown stalls, is already witnessing an elaborate makeover.

Nearly 7,500 people are expected at the opening ceremony, and by the end of the year a staggering 100,000 devotees per day are predicted to descend on Ayodhya, according to official estimates.

Magar women in Gulmi receive Naumati Baja



BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Gulmi, Jan. 17

Naumati Baja, a group of Nepali traditional musical instruments, has been handed over to women in Gulmi under the approved programme of the Ishma Rural Municipality in the district.

The musical instruments were specifically given to the Magar community women of Ward No. 4 of the rural municipality for cultural preservation.

The area has the dominating population of the Magar community.

Ward Chairman Bhagatsingh Khadka emphasised the need to preserve the disappearing traditional Naumati Baja and announced that the rural municipality would provide training to the women alongside the instrument transfer.

The rural municipality's objective is to culturally and economically empower Magar women by teaching them to play the instruments, and the rural municipality plans to offer training in playing the Naumati instrument as required. The Naumati Baja, valued at about Rs. 200,000, has been entrusted to the women.

The rural municipality expressed its intention to establish a women's Naumati instrument group in all wards if the women effectively learn to play the instrument.

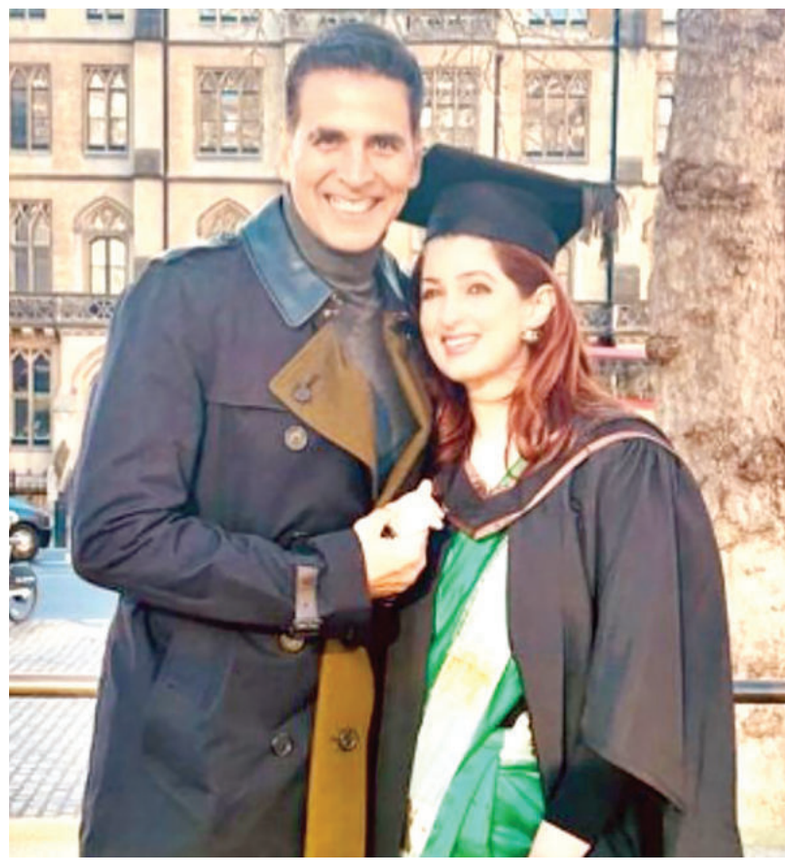
Vice-chair of the rural municipality Parbati Kunwar said that women and sisters would benefit from the initiative and urged them to make proper use of the Baja. She emphasised the necessity of fulfilling the purpose by ensuring that the instruments are not kept unused in someone's house.

The women who received the Naumati Baja expressed their joy and gratitude to the rural municipality.

They pledged to learn to play the instrument skillfully and expressed their commitment to inspiring others in the community to move forward.

Twinkle Khanna graduates from UK's Goldsmith College

PTI
Mumbai, Jan.17



Twinkle Khanna has completed a master's programme in fiction writing from Goldsmiths, University of London, and the actor-turned-author has said her graduation ceremony was 'even more perfect' than she ever imagined.

Khanna, who recently came out with the novel 'Welcome To Paradise', shared a video from the event on her official Instagram account on Tuesday.

'And it's here. Graduation day. My first day at Goldsmiths feels like it was both yesterday and years ago. A sunny day, a pretty sari, and having my family with me make this day even more perfect than I ever imagined,' she wrote.

Khanna, a former actor known for films such as 'Barsaat', 'Baadshah', 'Jodi No.1' and 'Mela', enrolled at the UK-based college in 2022.

'There comes a stage when the easiest way to grow is horizontally, but we have to push ourselves to grow in myriad other ways,' she further said in the post. Khanna's husband, actor Akshay Kumar accompanied her to the graduation ceremony.

In a post on X, Kumar congratulated his wife, whom he described as a 'super woman'.

'Two years ago when you told me you wanted to take up studies all over again, I wondered if you meant it. But the day I saw you work so hard and perfectly manage a full-fledged student life along with home, career, me and kids, I knew I had married a super woman. Today on your graduation, I also wish I had studied a bit more to know enough words to tell you how proud you make me, Tina. Congratulations and all my love,' the actor wrote.

Khanna, 50, and Kumar, 56, are celebrating their 23rd wedding anniversary on Wednesday. The couple are parents to son Aarav and daughter Nitara.

Two Malaysian filmmakers are charged with offending the religious feelings



AP
Malaysia, Jan. 17

The director and producer of a banned Malaysian film that explores the afterlife were charged Wednesday with offending the religious feelings of others in a rare criminal prosecution of filmmakers, slammed by critics as an attack on freedom of expression.

Mohamad Khairianwar Jailani, the director and co-scriptwriter of "Mentega Terbang," and producer Tan Meng Kheng pleaded not guilty to having a "deliberate intention of wounding the religious feelings of others" through the independent, low-budget film. If found guilty, they could face up to a year in jail, a fine or both.

Defense lawyer N. Surendran said the two believe the charge is "unreasonable and unconstitutional" because it violates their right to freedom of expression. "As far as we are concerned, these are groundless charges and we will challenge those charges in court," he said.

The film, which debuted at a regional film festival in 2021, revolves around a young Muslim girl who explores other religions to figure out where her ailing mother would go when she dies. Scenes that angered Muslims included ones showing the girl desiring to eat pork, which is forbidden in Islam, and pretending to drink holy water, and her father supporting her wish to leave Islam. It also sparked death threats against Khairianwar.

The film was briefly shown on a Hong Kong streaming platform last year before it was removed. The Home Ministry banned the film last September without giving any reason. The two filmmakers filed a suit challenging the government's decision before they were charged.

Race and religion are sensitive issues in Malaysia. Ethnic Malays account for two-thirds of the country's 33 million people and must be Muslims, with apostasy considered a sin. There are large ethnic Chinese and Indian minorities that are Buddhist, Hindu and Christian.

Critics say religious conservatism has been on the rise in Malaysia, after an influential Malay-Islam alliance won strong gains in the November 2022 general election. Human Rights Watch accused Prime Minister Anwar Ibrahim's government of prosecuting the two filmmakers to win political support from Malays.

Pharrell Williams' sophomore collection at Louis Vuitton showcases Americana, Native American spirit



AP
PARIS , Jan. 17

It was Wild West meets melting pot America at the Louis Vuitton Fall-Winter 2024 men's show Tuesday, where musician-turned-designer Pharrell Williams unveiled his highly-anticipated sophomore collection.

The show, set against the dramatic silhouette of the Louis Vuitton Foundation in Paris, masterfully channeled Americana, with Native American designs mixing with modern luxury and showcasing Williams' unique vision for the powerhouse.

Celebrity guests including Bradley Cooper, Omar Sy and Carey Mulligan gathered to witness a boulder-laden landscape that evoked the rugged terrains of an idealized America. The collection itself was a vibrant celebration of the American spirit, dripping in the famed confidence of Williams — a lauded music star who is a newcomer to fashion design at this level.

The designs emphasized loose proportions, reflecting a modern take on classic American silhouettes. Models — male and female — strutted down the runway in leather cowboy hats, cowhide valises, and checkered denim jackets adorned with bull badges, their cowboy boots boasting shiny metal points. Rodeo jackets shimmered with intricate embroideries, showcasing the luxurious craftsmanship synonymous with the LVMH-owned brand.

The show highlighted the dazzling Vegas-style suiting — jackets with glimmering stripes paired with flared pants, exuding an energy reminiscent of the city's iconic Strip. The collection also featured oversized jackets, including a statement-making gangster-style fur coat, in bold reinterpretations of traditional Western wear.

Yet, the soul of the collection is its collaboration with Dakota and Lakota nation artists, a partnership that could be seen in intricate designs on scarves, bags, and blankets with floral and geometric patterns telling stories of heritage and identity.

"Pharrell wanted to bring out the Native American spirit, (...) he wanted to showcase we're still here, we're still resilient," Rebecca Brady, 54, a Native American from New Town, North Dakota, told The Associated Press.

Beyond the fashion, the event turned into a cultural spectacle. VIP guests enjoyed Louis Vuitton-branded hamburgers in a Champagne-fueled barbecue, symbolizing a quirky blend of high fashion and classic Americana. The atmosphere was further charged with performances by Mumford & Sons and artists from the Native American nations.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: Your responsibilities might be tougher to handle than normal. If you care for someone, they may be sick or hurt in a way that requires more of your care and attention, or your career could be swamped.

Taurus: The power to learn new information is yours! Regardless of how much you normally enjoy lessons, your focus is so much stronger at this time that you may feel like your brain is a sponge.

Gemini: You might be depending on other people to support you now. No matter how independent you typically are, you're allowed to need someone else to fill in the gaps every once in a while..

Cancer: You can connect with someone else on a deeper level. There may have been an element to someone in your life that always prevented you from getting to know them better, or they could simply be someone who has strong emotional.

Leo: There are many things you can do in the present. You might have previously been letting your worries get the best of you, focusing on things that were out of your grasp or that could no longer be changed.

Virgo: You could be noticing facets of social connections that once slipped your attention. Perhaps you're observing what a friend of yours does and doesn't like, their hopes and dreams, or their fears.

Libra: Your inner voice can guide you to your highest path. The universe is strengthening your intuition, providing you with a gut feeling to steer you away from the people who aren't meant for you and toward those who would be supportive and helpful.

Scorpio: You're able to cooperate with others at this time. This issue might reside in you being placed in a group academic project, coordinating with co-workers, or even working on your own project with a few of your friends.

Sagittarius: A good living space can be used to create stability in your life. While you may be a wild child in other aspects of your existence, everyone needs to build their own happy place, a refuge that they can return to when things are getting too chaotic.

Capricorn: Your strength might lead others to think that you're not going through anything difficult. You may try to put on a brave face in the face of difficult situations or sorrow -- others could then believe that there is nothing wrong.

Aquarius: Spirituality could confuse you throughout the day. It's possible that you truly want to stay grounded, but the complexities and confounding energies of life keep leading you to feel misguided on your soul's journey.

Pisces: Your community may need your time at present. It should be something you have time to do -- perhaps you'll be a shoulder to cry on, but it could be a bigger task, like volunteering for those who have been affected.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





Bagmati, Karnali register their second win in low scoring matches on Day 5



PHOTO: CAN

Surya Tamang of Bagmati took a five-wicket haul against Tribhuwan Army Club on Wednesday.

BY NAYAK PAUDEL
Kathmandu, Jan. 17

Bagmati Province was able to defeat at least one of the departmental teams, the Tribhuwan Army Club, in the ongoing PM Cup Men's National Cricket Tournament to register its second win in four matches.

Losing the opening match of the tournament against Nepal Police Club and the second one against Nepal APF Club, Bagmati was able to register its first win against Madhes on Tuesday.

Surya Tamang shined once again for Bagmati as he took a five-wicket-haul on Wednesday to bowl out Army's team at 97 in 27.1 overs. Tamang's bowling stats against Madhes was a six-wicket-haul, including a hat-trick.

Tamang also had a chance to get his second hat-trick at Mulpani International Cricket Ground as he bowled Kushal Malla for a golden duck after sending Bhim Sharki back to the pavilion in the 17th over. However, he missed the third one.

Basir Ahamad, Sandeep Rajali and Shahab Alam were the other victims of Tamang. Krijan Gurung bowled Army's captain Binod Bhandari, who scored a century in the team's first match against Madhes on Monday, when he was at 28 runs. Pratish GC and Rijan Dhakal took two wickets each for Bagmati.

Nevertheless, Bagmati struggled to chase the low target of 98 runs in 300 balls as five wickets fell until the 11th over when the team was at 54. Sompal Kami struck the stumps thrice to show the way outside to Ashuosh Ghiraiya, Rabin Joshi and Pratik Shrestha. Jitendra Mukhiya also bowled out Ishan Pandey and Ashok Poudel. Bagmati's captain Rit Gautam was struck leg before by Shahab Alam before claiming the wicket of Bipin Acharya.

Acharya was the final wicket that Bagmati lost before winning the match in 22.1 overs. Pratish GC, who hit a half-century in the previous match, won the match with a six. He remained not out at 21 runs with Rijan Dhakal (0 runs off 5 balls) to take the team to 103 in the loss of seven wickets.

On the other hand, Karnali was able to defend a not-so-small target compared to the one posted by Army in another match of Day 5 held at Bhairahawa Cricket Ground.

In a match that started late due to bad weather, officials reduced the game to 45 overs each. Electing to field first, Lumbini Province was able to restrict Karnali at a score of 184 runs in the loss of nine wickets after playing all 45 overs.

Dinesh Adhikari, a right-arm medium pacer, and Dipendra Rawat, a middle-order batsman, were the ones who helped Karnali cross the 180-run-mark. While Adhikari scored a half-century, Rawat fell short of three runs for his 50 as he got caught behind the stumps in the 42nd over. Adhikari remained not out at 56 runs in 59 balls.

While Lumbini's winning chances were high as the target was chasable, its batting line-up crumbled in the chase. Seven batsmen, including five from the top and middle orders, scored in single digit for Lumbini.

It was thanks to the knock of 47 runs by Krishna Karki, who came in at seven, that helped Lumbini cross the 100-run-mark. After Karki's departure, Lumbini was left at 106 for 8 in 35.3 overs. The final wicket for Lumbini was of Avishek Gautam's in 41.2 overs.

Dinesh Adhikari, who was great with the bat, took three wickets for Karnali while Anuj Chanara and Dipendra Rawat claimed two each. Diwan Pun's only wicket of the match was of Lumbini's highest scorer Krishna Karki. After Day 5, Bagmati and Karnali are in the fourth and fifth position in the league table with APF as table topper.

Schoolgirl Andreeva thrashes Jabeur at Australian Open



PHOTO: AFP

Russia's Mirra Andreeva celebrates winning against Tunisia's Ons Jabeur.

AFP
Melbourne, Jan. 17

Playing her first main draw at Melbourne Park, Andreeva was electric in downing the three-time Grand Slam runner-up 6-0, 6-2 on Rod Laver Arena in just 54 minutes.

Ranked 47, it was her first win over a top-10 player, having burst onto the scene when she reached the fourth round 0at Wimbledon last year as a qualifier.

"I was really nervous before the match, but I saw that she was nervous too. It kind of helped me, because I know I'm not the only one who is nervous before the match," said Andreeva.

"I decided to just enjoy, because it's Rod Laver Arena, I'm playing against the person that I like. I decided just to play, and I think I played OK."

It was her second appearance on Melbourne's centre court after last year losing the girls' final to fellow Russian Alina Korneeva.

She admitted it left her "super upset" and drove her forward against Jabeur.

"Today when I saw that I play on Rod Laver, I said that this time I have to take my chance and I have to win on the big court for the first time, and so I did," she said.

Andreeva made her Grand Slam bow at the French Open last year with a run to the third round after coming through qualifying, ahead of her exploits at Wimbledon.

In her only other Grand Slam, she lost in the second round of the US Open to eventual champion Coco Gauff.

She is pursuing her dream of a tennis career while still juggling school.

"I still have to do a lot of school. It actually started two days ago, so I have to do it," she said, adding "I don't like chemistry".

At such a young age, Andreeva is restricted by the WTA Tour in the number of tournaments she can play and she said it was too early to be thinking about what how far she can climb up the rankings.

"I mean, I'm 16. Why do I have to think about the rankings? I'm going a bit higher, and so my goal is to go higher and higher, maybe for a little bit but still higher," she said.

"So I don't know. I just try not to think about that and just to think about tennis and that's it."

The first set against the Tunisian was a 20-minute demolition job, with 29-year-old Jabeur completely out of touch.

She won only eight points across the six games, and just three from the baseline, while making 10 unforced errors.

Her serve was not firing, with only 38 percent of first serve points won and just 13 percent on second serve.

What are the Premier League's profit and sustainability rules?

AFP
Manchester, Jan. 17

The financial regulations have been put in place to minimise the losses clubs can make as they chase success on the field.

Everton have already been hit this season with a 10-point deduction for exceeding the allowable losses at the end of the 2021/22 season.

AFP Sport looks at the rules and why they are often criticised.

What are the rules?

Premier League clubs are allowed to lose a maximum of £105 million ($134 million) across a three-year assessment period. However, for every season a club was in the second-tier Championship, that amount is reduced by £22 million.

Forest, therefore, were only permitted losses of £61 million as they were promoted back to the Premier League for the first time in 23 years in 2022/23.

There are a number of deductions allowed for spending on costs that are deemed to be in the general interest of the club and the game. These include spending on infrastructure, youth development and women's football.

Clubs also use an accounting tool called amortisation to minimise the impact of transfer fees in their accounts. For example, a player signed for £50 million on a five-year contract will appear as a £10 million charge for each of the five years rather than a £50 million upfront cost, no matter when the cash is actually transferred between the clubs.

That was part of Chelsea's rationale in dishing out eight-year contracts last year to Premier League record signings Enzo Fernandez and Moises Caicedo.

A change to Premier League rules from December now imposes a limit of five years on spreading the cost of a transfer in the club's books.

Why were they introduced?

A form of the profit and sustainability rules has been in place since the 2013/14 season. That followed the introduction of financial fair play rules by UEFA, designed to bring down rampant loss making in European football and protect clubs from going bust. In 2010, Portsmouth became the only Premier League club to date to go into administration.

"They were brought in in 2013-14 with the specific purpose of ensuring that unsustainable spending couldn't go too far and a wrapper was put around how much clubs could invest in pursuit of their aims," Premier League chief executive Richard Masters said on Tuesday.

Why are they controversial?

Financial sustainability rules are designed to limit clubs to spend within their means of what they generate in revenue. However, as a result they are often criticised for helping the established elite clubs maintain their privileged position as they make the most money thanks to larger stadiums, better commercial deals due to bigger fanbases and are regularly involved in lucrative European football.

Despite being backed by the Saudi sovereign wealth fund, Newcastle chief executive Darren Eales admitted last week that the Magpies may be forced to sell one of their prized assets to be able to invest again in Eddie Howe's squad due to profit and sustainability rules.

"It is counter-intuitive and part of the inherent system of PSR that there is an incentive to trade your players if you want to re-invest, by the nature of the boundaries," said Eales.

Many believe PSR rules were designed specifically to put the brakes on spending of the state-backed clubs like Newcastle, Manchester City and Paris Saint-Germain. City now boast the biggest revenue in the Premier League, making a English record £713 million for their treble-winning season in 2022/23.

However, the English champions are facing over 100 Premier League charges for historic breaches of financial regulations. City lost hundreds of millions in amassing a competitive squad and off-field infrastructure in the early years after an Abu Dhabi-backed takeover in 2008.

WEATHER

Thursday

Sunrise at 6:56 am, Sunset at 5:33 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Thursday)

Generally cloudy in the hilly regions of Koshi, Gandaki, Karnali and Sudur Pashchim Provinces, and partly cloudy to mainly fair in rest of the country.

Expected Temp.: 17-19 Rain Probability: 0%

Wednesday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	14.6	3.5	0.0
Dipayal	23.2	3.3	0.0
Dhangadi	17.3	5.6	0.0
Birendranagar	23.2	5.3	0.0
Nepalgunj	16.2	9.5	0.0
Jumla	13.7	-4.9	0.0
Ghorahi	22.3	7.4	0.0
Pokhara	21.2	8.3	0.0
Bhairahawa	13.6	9.2	0.0
Simara	12.5	10.0	0.0
Kathmandu	18.1	4.5	0.0
Okhaldhunga	16.0	6.8	Traces
Taplejung	13.4	4.8	0.0
Dhankuta	23.3	7.8	0.0
Biratnagar	13.6	11.2	0.0
Janakpur	14.0	11.0	0.0
Dharan	23.0	10.0	0.0*
Lumle	17.1	6.5	0.0*
Janakpur	18.8	9.4	0.0*
Jiri	16.6	0.7	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 18, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.73	Rs. 133.33
Euro	1	Rs. 144.35	Rs. 145.00
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.38	Rs. 169.14
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 153.58	Rs. 154.27
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 87.02	Rs. 87.41
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.17	Rs. 98.61
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 98.75	Rs.99.19
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.98	Rs. 9.02
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.45	Rs. 18.53
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.39	Rs. 35.55
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.40	Rs. 36.56
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.74	Rs. 3.75
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.14	Rs. 36.30
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.14	Rs. 28.26
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.86	Rs. 9.90
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.68	Rs. 12.73
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.35	Rs. 19.44
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.96	Rs. 17.04
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 431.07	Rs. 433.02
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 352.09	Rs. 353.68

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.



Allen's record 137 helps New Zealand series-clinching Pakistan T20 win

AFP
Wellington, Jan. 17

The Black Caps, sent in to bat in game three of the five-match series, won by 45 runs after posting a colossal 224 for seven and restricting Pakistan to 179 for seven.

It followed their victories by 46 and 21 runs respectively in the first two matches.

The swashbuckling Allen, following on from his 74 off 41 balls in game two, frequently belted the ball out of the ground as he smashed 16 sixes and five fours in his whirlwind innings.

The opener's 137 is the highest score by a New Zealander in a T20 International, surpassing the previous best of 123 set by Brendon McCullum, and it equalled the world record of 16 sixes in an innings held by Afghanistan's Hazratullah Zazai.

He dominated the bowling, taking 27 off one over by Haris Rauf with three sixes, two fours and a single.

Rauf conceded 60 off his four overs while Mohammad Nawaz gave up 44 and Shaheen Afridi 43 on a dismal day with the ball for Pakistan.

After the early dismissal of Devon Conway for seven, Allen and Tim Seifert put on 125 for the second wicket, with Seifert only contributing 31 as he opted for singles to keep the hard-hitting opener on strike.

The umpires had to call for replacement balls three times, after Allen smacked missiles out of the ground.

The opener was eventually undone in the 18th over when he was bowled by an off-cutter from Zaman Khan, who then applauded the New Zealand batsman as he left the field.

In reply, Pakistan never looked like getting close to the required 11.25 run rate. They reached 95 for two in the 11th over, but saw a clutch of wickets derail their chase, losing four for just 39 runs.

> Rauf conceded 60 off his four overs while Mohammad Nawaz gave up 44 and Shaheen Afridi 43 on a dismal day with the ball for Pakistan.

Babar Azam top-scored with 58 off 37 deliveries while Mohammad Nawaz contributed 28 off 15 in a late cameo.

The remaining two matches are in Christchurch on Friday and Sunday.

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